

Glossary

Algae Plantlike organisms that can make food using solar energy. Most are single-celled microbes.

Atmosphere The layer or layers of gas held around a planet or moon by gravity.

Atom The smallest particle of an element such as iron. Compounds have more than one kind of atom.

Axis An imaginary line that something spins around. Earth spins on such a line.

Bacteria Microscopic organisms that have a simple single-celled structure, and no cell nuclei or other distinct internal structures.

Batholith A very large mass of igneous rock such as granite, exposed in some places but mostly buried underground.

Biome A community of animals and plants on a large scale, defined mainly by vegetation—for example, rainforest.

Climate The typical or average weather in a particular area.

Cold front The leading edge of a moving mass of cold air, where it pushes beneath a mass of warm air.

Compound A substance containing two or more elements, formed by a chemical reaction that bonds their atoms together. Water is a compound of hydrogen and oxygen.

Condense To turn from a gas to a liquid.

Continental crust A thick slab of relatively light rock that “floats” on the heavier rock of Earth’s mantle and forms a continent.

Continental shelf The submerged fringe of a continent, forming the relatively shallow floor of a coastal sea.

Convection Circulating currents in gases and liquids such as air and water, and even in hot, mobile rock, which are driven by differences in temperature.

Cyclone An area of low pressure, where warm air is sucked in and rises. It flows counterclockwise in the northern hemisphere and clockwise in the southern hemisphere. Also, a tropical storm in the Indian and southwest Pacific Oceans.

Delta A fan of sand and silt at the mouth of a river. The river usually flows through it in several channels.

Ecosystem The complex interactions of different organisms with one another and with their environment.

Element A substance that is made up of just one type of atom.

Equator A line of latitude around the middle of Earth at its widest point.

Erosion Wearing away, usually of rock, by natural forces such as flowing water or ocean waves breaking on the shore.

Evaporate To turn from a liquid to a gas or vapor.

Extinct Having died out completely. An extinct species has gone for good.

Fault A fracture in rock, along which rock masses move—this sometimes causes earthquakes.

Fissure A deep, narrow gap, such as between rocks.

Fjord A deep valley gouged by a glacier, which is now flooded by the sea.

Fossil The remains, imprint, or trace of a life form preserved in rock.

Fossil fuels Coal, oil, and gas made over millions of years from the remains of long-dead plants and microbes.

Genetic Relating to genes and inherited traits in living things.

Gravity The force of attraction exerted by a large object such as a planet, which holds things on the surface and in orbit.

Habitat A place where wildlife lives.

Hot spot A zone of volcanic activity caused by a plume of heat beneath Earth’s crust. If the crust is moving, the hot spot creates chains of volcanoes.

Igneous rock Rock formed by the cooling of molten magma or volcanic lava. Most igneous rocks are made of interlocking crystals and are very hard.

Impermeable Rock that is waterproof and does not soak up water.